FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Public opinion is fundamental to democracy because, ultimately, a state is built on the consent of its people. That said, public opinion is not static. Politicians elected by the will of the people can rest on their laurels only at their peril. Sooner or later, the chickens come home to roost. Smart politicians keep track of their electorate's changing sentiment, whatever means they employ for it. Opinion polls, rigorously conducted, are one instrument many countries use, and take seriously. INDIA TODAY has always believed such surveys to be the most scientific and objective way to gauge the public mood. They may not always be right in predicting the number of seats in an election, but they capture the views of more people than any individual can hope to do.

We began the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll in 2003 to assess people's perception of personalities and popular issues. Conducted biannually, once before Republic Day, and then on the eve of Independence Day, it has since become a reliable dipstick of Indian public opinion. As the MOTN exercise enters its second decade, we have refined our methodology and increased our sample size. For one, we have onboarded a new independent polling agency, CVoter. Our January 2022 MOTN poll interviews 60,141 respondents—more than five times our usual sample size. CVoter has also been keeping a daily tracker since 2019 with a sample size of 1,200 and has been in the polling business since 2000.



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Our survey comes at an interesting time. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government is halfway through its second term in office. A midterm assessment is a key measure of a government's popularity, particularly in extraordinary times such as these when three waves of the Covid-19 pandemic over two years have upended the economy, destroyed lives and damaged livelihoods. A lethal second wave spurred by the highly infectious Delta variant claimed over 400,000 lives last year and left long-term health and financial implications for thousands more. Currently, the country is in the grip of a third Covid wave, triggered by the Omicron strain. While regarded as a milder variant, it has clouded the gradual economic recovery that began in the second quarter of the financial year, as business activity inched up to pre-Covid levels.

The urban unemployment rate rose to 9.3 per cent, and rural employment to 7.3 per cent in December 2021, from 8.2 per cent and 6.4 per cent the previous month, according to the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data. CMIE estimates six million salaried jobs were lost in November 2021. India's benchmark inflation rate, measured by the Consumer Price Index, was 5.6 per cent in December 2021, the highest in five months. Adding to these economic woes is the Chinese military buildup in eastern Ladakh, a standoff that has lasted nearly two years, with no resolution in sight.

The real worry for respondents this time, as in the previous MOTN survey, is the state of the economy. As many as 48 per cent cite unemployment and prices as their major concerns. The number of people who believe their economic status has deteriorated remains high at 31.8 per cent, somewhat similar to the August 2021 findings, but it has doubled from January 2021. This implies that the government has not addressed economic issues adequately. Worse, another 42.7 per cent think the government's economic policies have helped only big business.

As counterintuitive as it may seem, Prime Minister Modi and his government seem to have held a steady course in public perception. If general elections were held today, MOTN projects that the BJP will fall just one seat short of a simple majority (272 seats in the 543-member Lok Sabha) but win 296 seats as part of the NDA. The dip from the BJP and NDA's current tallies—303 and 352 seats—can be attributed to the unprecedented challenges of the pandemic and possibly the mid-term fatigue most governments face. However, 58.7 per cent feel very satisfied/satisfied by the government's overall performance.

No wonder Prime Minister Modi's personal popularity is rising. From an all-time MOTN low of 54 per cent last August, it has climbed back to 62 per cent, though it is still lower than the 78 per cent in August 2020. In the best choice for PM stakes, Modi has widened the gap with his nearest political competitor, Rahul Gandhi—52.5 per cent versus 6.8 per cent. He is, in fact, adjudged the best prime minister India has had, head and shoulders above even his late mentor, A.B. Vajpayee, who is a distant second. Nearly 53 per cent of respondents dismiss the opposition parties' attempts to hold the government to account.

The latest MOTN makes it clear that despite all their concerns, respondents trust Modi to lead them out of their troubles. A larger than life figure in today's political landscape, the faith and trust in him has been a constant in our surveys since his election in 2014, despite the challenges the country has faced. Hence, our headline for the cover this week, 'In Modi We Trust'.

India's successful vaccination campaign has come as a booster dose for Modi and his government's standing. India has so far administered 1.5 billion doses. Currently, 97 per cent of the country's adult population has received the first dose of the vaccine and 70 per cent have received both doses. An overwhelming 82 per cent believe the vaccination drive has been a success; 49 per cent deem the government's efforts outstanding.

Respondents have also endorsed the government's stance on its two biggest external challenges, China and Pakistan. Seventy five per cent feel the Centre has handled the border standoff with China very well or satisfactorily. Over 55 per cent do not want the government to resume talks with Pakistan.

However, public concerns on the current state of Indian democracy, however, remain high—43.7 per cent suggest democracy is in danger, up from 42 per cent last August; 48.9 per cent believe people are scared to protest or express themselves on public platforms for fear of arrest. This is a marginal dip from the 51 per cent who felt this in August 2021. Privacy is an overwhelming concern for 56.4 per cent of digital media users. These are fundamental issues to be addressed for India to be a robust democracy.

The big takeaway from our present survey is that while the public trusts Prime Minister Modi's leadership and his political capital remains intact, he needs to deliver on the economic front and fulfill the high expectations people have of him.

(Aroon Purie)